

ROUTE OPTIMIZATION

Recommended Route (14 Days): China-then-Vietnam Open-Jaw Circuit

Fly into HKG, fly out of DAD. Eliminates backtracking through China.



Hub	Days	Region	Primary Draw
Beijing	1–5	North China	Forbidden City, Great Wall, hutongs
Hanoi	6–8	Northern Vietnam	Old Quarter food, Hoan Kiem Lake
Đà Nẵng / Hội An	9–13	Central Vietnam	Beach resort, Ancient Town, My Son
Home	14	Departure	Open-jaw exit via Đà Nẵng (DAD)

Home (arrive) → [HKG: Flight 15–18 hrs (US)] → [HK → Guangzhou: High-speed rail ~47 min] → [Guangzhou → Hanoi: Flight ~2.5 hrs] → [Hanoi → Đà Nẵng: Flight ~1.25 hrs] → [Đà Nẵng → Home: Flight 15–20 hrs]

✓ : ~2.5 transit-equivalent days / 14 = 18% — under 20% ✓

TRAVELER PROFILE

CHINA · VIETNAM

TRAVEL INTELLIGENCE Couple (traveler + wife) · China → Vietnam · September 1–14, 2026 (14 days). Budget \$20,000 USD for both travelers. Constraint: Avoid peak tourist hours.



DESTINATION
China → Vietnam



DATES
September 1–14, 2026 (14 days)



PARTY
Couple (traveler + wife)



BUDGET
\$20,000 USD for both travelers



PRIORITIES
Shopping · Food · Nature



PHYSICAL
Both travelers in excellent physical condition

SEASONALITY SCORECARD

	September	October	June
Heat	Shoulder — manageable	Cooler	Peak monsoon heat
Crowds	Moderate	Lower	Domestic peak
Rain	Late monsoon tail	Drier north	Heavy south
Beach (Đà Nẵng)	Warm water OK	Ideal	Storm risk
Value / splurge	Vietnam splurge window	Strong	Off-season deals
Fit score	34/40	36/40	22/40

September balances heat constraints with beach time in Vietnam and shoulder pricing in China.

- ✓

September in both China and Vietnam means heat + humidity + possible typhoon/rain — itinerary must have strong rainy-day fallbacks
- ✓

Vietnam resort stay should be clustered for relaxation (not fragmented across cities)
- ✓

China portion should prioritize efficiency: maximize cultural/shopping value without over-scheduling
- ✓

HKG entry → high-speed rail to Guangzhou for mainland China segment; then flight to Vietnam (no overland China–Vietnam border)
- ✓

Hong Kong and mainland China are separate immigration regimes — plan visas and apps for both

FOOD & DINING STRATEGY

PROFILE INTELLIGENCE

China → Vietnam · Sept 1–14, 2026 ·
Couple · \$20K all-in · Splurge in Vietnam ·
Priorities: shopping, food, nature, history ·
Avoid crowds & peak heat.

FOOD & DINING INTELLIGENCE

- **Beijing:** \$100–150/day for two — Mix of street + one upscale dinner per day
- **Hanoi:** \$60–100/day for two — Street food is cheap; Metropole breakfast is included
- **Đà Nẵng / Hội An:** \$100–200/day for two — Resort meals are priced up; street food is very cheap
- **Total ~14 days:** ~\$1,600–2,500 — Well within budget

REGIONAL HIGHLIGHTS

REGIONAL

BEIJING

Key: Peking Duck ()
Da Dong (); Qianjude; Duck de Chine
Best neighborhoods: Pancakes, scallions, hoisin sauce

HANOI

Key: Phở Bò (beef pho)
Phở Gia Truyền (49 Bat Dan St); Phở Lý Quốc Sư
Best neighborhoods: Bean sprouts, lime, basil, chili

ĐÀ NẴNG / HỘI AN

Key: Cao Lầu
Only authentic in Hội An; Morning Glory restaurant
Best neighborhoods: Pork, herbs, crunchy rice crackers



DAY-BY-DAY MEAL MAPPING

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12	13	14
Context	Beijing arrival	Forbidden City	Great Wall	Temple/Shopping	Summer Palace/depart	Transit Beijing→Hanoi	Hanoi	Transit Hanoi→Đà Nẵng	Marble Mountains	Hội An	Fitting + Son Trà	My Son + pickup	Beach day	Departure
Meal Strategy	 Duck de Chine near Wangfujing	 Ghost Street hotpot	 Da Dong Peking Duck (book ahead)	 Sanlitun area restaurant	 Airport or early hotel dinner	 Phở on arrival in Hanoi	 Night market or Bún Chả	 Resort restaurant	 Mỹ Khê seafood restaurant	 Hội An lantern district dinner	 Sky 36 rooftop bar + dinner	 Resort or Đà Nẵng riverside	 NON La restaurant (book ahead)	 Plane

Cooking class: Morning Glory Cooking School — market tour at 8 AM + hands-on cooking; approx \$35/person; book in advance

MASTER ITINERARY

Days 1–5

Day 1 — Tuesday, Sept 1: ARRIVAL (Soft)

Time	Activity
Transfer	Airport Express to Central/TST (~24 min)
Evening	Victoria Harbour promenade (TST) — Symphony of Lights 8 PM (optional)

 **Low Energy:** Hotel lounge only

Day 2 — Wednesday, Sept 2: Peak + Central

Time	Activity
Morning (8 AM)	Victoria Peak via Peak Tram — before tour buses; Sky Terrace views
Midday	Lunch Central (Yung Kee roast goose or Capo Italian if Western break)
Afternoon	Central shopping — IFC Mall, Landmark, PMQ design shops
Evening	Star Ferry Central ↔ TST at sunset; rooftop drink (Aqua or Sevva)

 Low Energy: Skip Peak Tram hike; bus 15 to Peak

Day 3 — Thursday, Sept 3: Stanley + Food

Time	Activity
Morning	Bus/taxi to Stanley Market — waterfront, relaxed shopping
Midday	Late brunch Stanley — beach walk (Stanley Main Beach)
Afternoon	Causeway Bay (Times Square, local boutiques) OR Sheung Wan antiques
Evening	Temple Street Night Market (after 7 PM) — food stalls, atmosphere

 **Low Energy:** Causeway Bay only; skip Temple Street

Next: Days 6–10

Day 4 — Friday, Sept 4: HK → Guangzhou (Transit-light)

Time	Activity
Morning	Check out HK; West Kowloon → Guangzhou South high-speed rail (~47 min)
Afternoon	Shamian Island — colonial architecture, quiet tree-lined streets
Evening	Pearl River night cruise or Riverside dining (Binjiang Road)

 **Low Energy:** Hotel rest; single neighbourhood stroll

Day 5 — Saturday, Sept 5: Culture + Shopping

Time	Activity
Morning	Chen Clan Ancestral Hall — Lingnan architecture, folk art
Midday	Taikoo Hui / Tee Mall — luxury shopping, air-conditioned
Afternoon	Beijing Road pedestrian zone — snacks, local brands
Evening	Cantonese dinner (Bingsheng or Panxi Restaurant — book ahead)

 **Low Energy:** Mall-only afternoon

Day 6 — Sunday, Sept 6

Time	Activity
Arrive Hanoi	e-visa immigration; Grab to Old Quarter hotel (no airport taxis)
Evening	Hoan Kiem Lake loop; pho at Pho Gia Truyen (Bat Dan)

 Low Energy: Hotel dinner only

Day 7 — Monday, Sept 7: Old Quarter + Temple of Literature

Time	Activity
Morning (8:30)	Hoan Kiem Lake + Ngoc Son Temple
Mid-morning	Old Quarter guild streets; Dong Xuan Market (brief)
Afternoon	Temple of Literature — gardens, quiet
Evening	Ta Hien beer street OR weekend night market

 Low Energy: Lake + café afternoon

Day 8 — Tuesday, Sept 8: Hanoi → Đà Nẵng (SOFT)

Time	Activity
Morning	Ho Chi Minh Mausoleum complex (early; closed Mon/Fri)
Afternoon	Check-in Mỹ Khê beach resort — beach sunset walk

 Low Energy: Resort only

Next: Days 11–14

Day 9 — Wednesday, Sept 9: Marble Mountains + Beach

Time	Activity
Morning	Marble Mountains (caves, cool interiors)
Midday	Resort late brunch + pool
Afternoon	Mỹ Khê Beach walk
Evening	Seafood at Bê Mặn (My An)

 Low Energy: Full resort day

Day 10 — Thursday, Sept 10: Hội An Ancient Town

Time	Activity
Morning (8 AM)	UNESCO Ancient Town before crowds
Mid-morning	Tailor consultation — Yaly / Bebe / A Dong (2 fittings min)
Evening	Lantern-lit old town + river candle boats

Day 11 — Friday, Sept 11: Fitting + Sơn Trà

Time	Activity
Morning	Tailor fitting
Late morning	Sơn Trà Peninsula — Lady Buddha, langurs
Afternoon	Resort spa/pool
Evening	Sky 36 rooftop (Novotel) — city/coast views

 Low Energy: Fitting + resort only

Day 12 — Saturday, Sept 12: My Son + Pickup

Time	Activity
Late morning	Hội An tailor final pickup
Afternoon	Beach

Day 13 — Sunday, Sept 13: Final Beach + Shopping

Time	Activity
Morning	Sunrise Mỹ Khê walk
Midday	Farewell resort brunch
Afternoon	Vincom / Indochina Riverside — coffee, lacquerware
Evening	NON La or Madame Lân — farewell dinner

Day 14 — Monday, Sept 14: DEPARTURE

Time	Activity
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ACCOMMODATION STRATEGY

ACCOMMODATION STRATEGY

ACCOMMODATION

- 4–5★ on US booking platforms; splurge in Vietnam.
- Booking Strategy
- Đà Nẵng resort (Sept is shoulder but resorts fill) — NOW — 3–4 months out · IHG.com, Fusion direct, or Hyatt.com
- Beijing (Sept is not peak season) — 6–8 weeks out · peninsula.com direct or Hotels.com
- Hanoi (Metropole fills fast year-round) — 6–8 weeks out · Accor.com or Booking.com
- Beijing early arrival (Day 1): Request early check-in when booking; Peninsula is good at accommodating; arrive mid-morning and bags can be held if room not ready
- Hanoi late arrival (Day 6 evening): Room pre-blocked; Metropole concierge meets at airport if arranged
- Đà Nẵng arrival midday (Day 8): Request early check-in; resort can arrange lunch before room ready
- Đà Nẵng late checkout (Day 14): Request late checkout (2 PM typical for 5-star); luggage storage available if earlier

ACCOMMODATION BUDGET SUMMARY			
City	Nights	Est. Cost	Notes
Beijing (Peninsula)	5	\$2,000–2,500	Value-conscious luxury
Hanoi (Metropole)	2	\$600–800	Iconic; worth it
Đà Nẵng (InterCon or Fusion)	5	\$2,000–3,500	Splurge as intended
Total	12	\$4,600–6,800	Within budget; leaves \$13–15K for flights, activities, food, shopping

Lodging only — flights separate.

BUDGET BREAKDOWN & NEIGHBORHOODS

HANOI — NEIGHBORHOOD		
Factor	Choice	Why
Neighborhood	Old Quarter / Hoan Kiem Lake district	

ĐÀ NẴNG / HỘI AN BASE — NEIGHBORHOOD		
Factor	Choice	Why
Neighborhood	Mỹ Khê Beach / Non Nước Beach, Đà Nẵng (NOT Hội An town)	

TOP PICKS & RECOMMENDATIONS

Hanoi

Top Hotel Options (US Bookable)

- Sofitel Legend Metropole Hanoi — 5★ · \$280–400/night · The iconic Hanoi hotel (1901); French colonial grandeur; within 5 min walk of Hoan Kiem; bunker tour on-site (Cold War history); book on Accor or Booking.com
- La Siesta Classic Hang Be — 4★ boutique · \$90–130/night · Best value luxury in Old Quarter; rooftop bar; all activities walking distance
- JW Marriott Hanoi — 5★ · \$200–300/night · Business district (Ba Đình); 20 min from Old Quarter; larger rooms, better pool; Marriott Bonvoy bookable

Đà Nẵng / Hội An Base

Top Resort Options (US Bookable)

- InterContinental Đà Nẵng Sun Peninsula — 5★ luxury resort · \$450–700/night · Cliff-top resort on Son Trà Peninsula; one of Asia's most spectacular resort settings; private beach; IHG bookable
- Fusion Maia Đà Nẵng — 5★ · \$320–500/night · All-spa-included resort (unlimited spa treatments included in rate); beachfront; on Booking.com/Expedia
- Pullman Đà Nẵng Beach Resort — 5★ · \$250–380/night · Mỹ Khê Beach; strong US platform presence; Accor bookable; reliable quality
- Vinpearl Luxury Đà Nẵng — 5★ · \$200–350/night · Good value for the star rating; beachfront; on Hotels.com

TYPHOON SEASON: BOOK FLEXIBLE CANCELLATION FOR ĐÀ NẴNG RESORT.

SHOPPING HUBS

REGIONAL SHOPPING HUBS

BEIJING

DAYS 2–5

Day	Spot	Buy
2–5	Beijing	Crafts, silk scarves, tea, sneakers

HANOI

DAY 7

Day	Spot	Buy
7	Hanoi	Coffee beans, lacquerware, small items

HỘI AN / ĐÀ NẴNG

DAYS 10–13

Day	Spot	Buy
10–13	Hội An / Đà Nẵng	Tailored clothing, silk, lanterns, pottery, final haul

HỘI AN TAILORING (DAYS 10–12); HONG KONG FOR LUXURY WATCHES/HANDBAGS (IFC, HARBOUR CITY); GUANGZHOU FOR FABRIC/VALUE; HANOI FOR COFFEE.

CULTURE & MUSEUMS MUSEUMS

CULTURE STRATEGY

CULTURE PHILOSOPHY

-  **One anchor site per day** — Avoid museum fatigue; match relaxed pace
-  **Book timed entry online** — Forbidden City and major sites sell out
-  **Early entry beats crowds** — Deal-breaker: large crowds

CROSS-HUB THEMES

- The Forbidden City's moat is 6 meters deep — constructed as a defensive system, the soil excavated was used to build the artificial Coal Hill (Jingshan) to the north
- Beijing has three times the number of hutong alleyways that remain from the Yuan Dynasty (1271–1368) as Venice has canals — over 1,000 hutongs still exist
- The Summer Palace's Long Corridor (728 meters) contains 14,000 individual paintings — no two are the same, making it the world's longest painted gallery

CROSS-TRIP MUSEUM FATIGUE CHECK

Days	Cultural Load
Days 1–2 (Beijing)	Moderate — arrival day light; Day 2 one major site
Day 3 (Great Wall)	High physical but simple; beware no return risk
Day 4 (Temple+shopping)	Light — Temple of Heaven is a park, not a museum
Day 5 (Summer Palace)	Light — garden walk
Days 6–7 (Hanoi)	Moderate — 2 temple visits + walking
Day 8 (Mausoleum + transit)	Light — 30 min only
Days 9–10 (Đà Nẵng/Hội An)	Day 9: zero museums; Day 10: Hội An Ancient Town (2–3 sites max)
Day 12 (My Son)	One focused site; 1.5 hrs; no fatigue risk

CHINA

Day	Site	Note
Best entry time	8:30 AM at Meridian Gate (before tour buses arrive at 9:30)	
Hidden corners	Treasure Gallery () in the northeast — less visited, contains finest imperial jewelry; Clock Gallery () in the west — magnificent European clocks gifted by Jesuits	
Booking	Tickets MUST be booked online in advance at pm.com.cn; timed entry; no walk-up sales	
Crowd avoidance	Inner courts (Yonghe Gong area) are far less visited than outer ceremonial halls	

VIETNAM

Day	Site	Note
Best entry time	8 AM before tour buses; or return after 5 PM for lantern atmosphere	
UNESCO ticket	Required to enter historic houses and assembly halls; ~120,000 VND; covers 5 sites of your choice; available at entrance gates	
Hidden corner	Phung Hung Old House (interior courtyard; family has lived here 8 generations); Tan Ky Old House (Japanese-Chinese architecture fusion; the family still lives here)	
Museum fatigue check	⚠️ Don't try to hit all 5 sites on one visit — 2–3 is the sweet spot for the relaxed pace profile	

SITES · CROWD TIMING · CROSS-BORDER TRANSITIONS

VIETNAM

Day	Site	Note
Ngoc Son Temple	Open 8 AM; cross the Huc Bridge (red lacquer arch bridge) over Hoan Kiem Lake; small, peaceful, not crowded; 30 min max	
Temple of Literature	Best at 9 AM–11 AM on weekdays; afternoon more crowded; the second and third courtyards are the most photogenic; doctoral stone steles with names of exam graduates carved in 1484 — you can find 500-year-old names	
Hidden corner	The Khue Van Cac Pavilion (Pavilion of Constellation of Literature) in the third courtyard — rarely noticed but the most iconic architectural element	
Open	Closed Mon and Fri; open Tue/Wed/Thu/Sat/Sun 7:30–10:30 AM only — Day 8 is a Tuesday ✓	

Forbidden City tickets at pm.com.cn; Mutianyu over Badaling for crowds.

Packing Strategy

DO NOT FORGET

SEPTEMBER CLIMATE

Beijing shoulder (20–26°C); Vietnam warm-humid with typhoon tail risk in central coast.

Schedule outdoor Vietnam time early AM / evening.

CORE DO NOT FORGET

-  1. Valid passports — valid until March 2027 minimum; both travelers
-  2. China visa — (in passport or printed approval letter)
-  3. Vietnam e-visa — printed copies (2 each; one in carry-on, one in checked)
-  4. Travel insurance policy number + 24/7 emergency line — saved in phone AND on paper
-  5. VPN activated on both phones — (ExpressVPN/NordVPN — must be installed BEFORE China entry)
-  6. All eSIMs activated — (Airalo China + Vietnam eSIMs downloaded and QR codes saved)

TECH / BATTERY SURVIVAL FOR LONG TRANSIT DAYS

TECH / BATTERY SURVIVAL FOR LONG TRANSIT DAYS

Item	Use
20,000 mAh power bank	4–5 full phone charges; 2 iPad charges
USB-C 65W laptop charger + adapter	Laptop charging at gate
Universal adapter (in carry-on on transit days)	Charge at airport lounges
Dual-port USB-C charging cube	Charge 2 devices simultaneously at hotel
Noise-canceling earbuds (AirPods Pro/Sony WH-1000XM5)	13-hr flight; focus
Downloaded movies/shows	No inflight WiFi assumed
Downloaded offline maps	Already in carry-on

CLIMATE · GEAR · BORDER-DAY CARRY-ON

LUGGAGE STRATEGY



Primary checked bag

Rimowa Original Check-In / Samsonite Spinner 27" — 27" per person; hardshell for Asia (overhead bin protection)



Carry-on

Rimowa Cabin / Away Carry-On — Must fit under seat or overhead per airline rules



Day bag

Lululemon/Cotopaxi 20L packable — Compresses to nothing; Great Wall hike bag; beach bag

Pack foldable duffel for Hôì An tailoring return.

PRINTABLE CHECKLIST HIGHLIGHTS

DOCUMENTS

- Both passports (valid through March 2027)
- China visa approved and in passport
- Vietnam e-visa (2 printed copies each)
- CBP Form 4457 for high-value US items
- Travel insurance policy + emergency number
- All hotel + flight confirmations printed

HEALTH

- Prescription medications (17-day supply)
- Imodium
- Antihistamine
- Ibuprofen / paracetamol
- Oral rehydration sachets
- DEET insect repellent
- SPF 50 sunscreen (2 bottles)
- Blister bandages (Compeed)
- Hand sanitizer
- Electrolyte tablets

ELECTRONICS

- Phones (fully charged) + chargers
- Power bank (20,000 mAh)
- Universal travel adapter
- Laptop + charger
- Noise-canceling earbuds
- GoPro / waterproof camera + charger
- VPN installed and tested
- Offline maps downloaded (Baidu Maps, Google Maps, Maps.me)
- All apps installed (DiDi, Grab, WeChat, Airalo eSIM)

MISC

- Small umbrella (foldable)
- Reusable water bottle (collapsible)
- Snacks for transit days
- Luggage locks (TSA-approved)
- Foldable duffel bag (for shopping return)
- Small bills (USD \$20s for tips/emergencies)

CLOTHING (PER PERSON)

- 5–6 lightweight shirts
- 3 pairs trousers/shorts
- 1 pair walking shoes (grip)
- 1 pair sandals
- 1 pair flip-flops
- 2 swimsuits
- 2–3 evening outfits
- 1 light jacket/cardigan
- Rain poncho
- Temple-appropriate clothing (covered shoulders + knees)
- Border-crossing outfit (see above)
- Compression socks (2 pairs)
- Underwear (7 pairs minimum; quick-dry recommended)

ETIQUETTE GUIDE

Daily Norms — China & Vietnam		
Situation	Do	Don't
• Don't tip	✓ Tipping is not customary and can embarrass service staff; exception: tour guides and porters (¥20–50/day acceptable and appreciated for guides); 5-star hotel staff follow international norms and won't refuse tips	✗
• Greet with a nod or slight bow	✓ Handshakes are acceptable at business settings; a respectful nod is sufficient for everyday interactions; no hugging strangers	✗
• Two hands for business cards/gifts	✓ Present and receive with both hands; this is a mark of respect; inspect what you receive before putting it away	✗
• Be direct about food/drink preferences	✓ Chinese hosts take pride in hospitality through food; politely declining requires firmness: " (Wǒ zhǐ bǎo le = I'm full); declining multiple times is expected before acceptance	✗
🏢 No photos inside government buildings and many temples	✓ Look for (no photography) signs; always ask at temples; the Forbidden City outer areas are fine, inner galleries sometimes not	✗
• Dress modestly at temples	✓ Shoulders and knees covered at Buddhist/Taoist temples; the White Cloud Temple (Taoist) is stricter than tourist-oriented Buddhist temples	✗
• Tip, but softly	✓ 10–15% at restaurants with table service; round up at street stalls; tip tour guides and drivers (\$1–2/person/day); nothing is expected but everything is appreciated	✗
👣 Remove shoes at temple entrances	✓ Always look for a pile of shoes; follow the lead of locals entering	✗
• Dress modestly at temples and pagodas	✓ Sarongs often available to borrow at temple entrances if you forget; tank tops alone are not sufficient	✗
• Don't touch the heads of adults or children	✓ In Vietnamese (and broadly Buddhist) culture, the head is sacred	✗
PART 6: CULTURE & ETIQUETTE		

Survival Phrases (Mandarin & Vietnamese)			
Phrase	Pronunciation	When to Use	Meaning
	Nǐ hǎo	Hello	Hello
	Xièxiè	Thank you	Thank you
	Bù kèqì	You're welcome	You're welcome
	Duìbuqǐ	Excuse me / Sorry	Excuse me / Sorry
	Duōshǎo qián?	How much?	How much?
	Tài guì le	Too expensive	Too expensive
	Wǒ bùyào	I don't want it	I don't want it
	Cèsuǒ zài nǎlǐ?	Where is the toilet?	Where is the toilet?
	Néng bǎng wǒ jiào Dìdì ma?	Can you call me a DiDi?	Can you call me a DiDi?
	Hǎo de	Okay / Got it	Okay / Got it
PART 6: CULTURE & ETIQUETTE			

China → Vietnam Transition		
Aspect	China (Beijing)	Vietnam (Hanoi/Hội An)
• Greeting	Nod, no touch	Friendly, may attempt handshake
• Tipping	Mostly no	Yes, appreciated
• Pace	Efficient, direct	Relaxed, meandering
• Eye contact	Moderate	Friendly, more direct
• English	Very limited	Moderate in tourist areas
• Noise level	Louder (normal)	Moderate
• Bargaining	Aggressive (markets)	Gentler, playful
• Food pace	Fast	Slow and social
PART 6: CULTURE & ETIQUETTE		

Temple & Shrine Etiquette		
Setting	Do	Avoid
China temples	Shoulders/knees covered; no flash where signed	Chopsticks upright in rice
Vietnam pagodas	Remove shoes; borrow sarong if offered	Touching adults' heads
Photos	Ask when unsure; respect signs	Drone without permit
PART 6: CULTURE & ETIQUETTE		

IMMIGRATION ENTRY

IMMIGRATION ENTRY

VJW · VISA-FREE · PASSPORT · TIMELINE

⚠ Red flag: Confirm current US–China visa policy at travel.state.gov before applying. Rules change; verify before June 2026 applications.

MAINLAND CHINA ENTRY (GUANGZHOU)

- Biometrics on first mainland entry in trip
- Hotels register foreign guests with police — confirm at check-in
- VPN legality: use only compliant services; download maps/apps before entry

BACKUP IF CHINA VISA DENIED

- Execute Option B from Step 02: HK-only China segment + unchanged Vietnam legs; drop Guangzhou nights.

HONG KONG SAR ENTRY

ITEM	DETAIL
Visa	Visa-free — US passport, tourism up to 90 days
Documents	Valid passport, onward ticket to Guangzhou/Vietnam, hotel confirmation
Port of entry	Hong Kong International (HKG)
Apply	No advance visa

VIETNAM ENTRY

ITEM	DETAIL
Visa	E-visa (90 days, single/multiple per approval)
Cost	~\$25 USD
Processing	~3 business days; apply ≥7 days before arrival
Portal	evisa.xuatnhapcanh.gov.vn
Port of entry	Noi Bai (HAN) — Guangzhou → Hanoi flight
Apply	July–August 2026

APPLICATION TIMELINE

WHEN	ACTION
Now	Confirm passport validity (both travelers)
June 2026	Apply mainland China L visa (both)
July 2026	Vietnam e-visa (both)
August 2026	Travel clinic; print visas + hotels + flights
Before HKG	VPN + DiDi + Baidu Maps installed
Sept 4	West Kowloon → Guangzhou rail; mainland entry at station

MAINLAND CHINA ENTRY (GUANGZHOU)

ITEM	DETAIL
Visa type	L Tourist (US citizens — no visa-free mainland)
Processing	~4–7 business days standard; expedited 2–3 days
Cost	~\$185 USD per applicant
Portal	Chinese Visa Application Service Center — [cvasc.com](https://www.cvasc.com)
Documents	Passport (6+ months validity), photo, itinerary, hotel bookings, round-trip/onward tickets
Apply window	~60–90 days before travel; earliest ~June 2026
Entry port	Guangzhou South (high-speed rail from West Kowloon) or CAN airport if flying

PASSPORT VALIDITY

JURISDICTION	VALIDITY	BLANK PAGES
Hong Kong	6+ months beyond Sept 14, 2026	1
Mainland China	6+ months beyond Sept 14, 2026	2
Vietnam	6+ months	1
Action	Valid through March 2027+	4+ blank pages total

Mode: International flight (Cathay Pacific, United, Singapore Airlines) - Airport: HKG (Hong Kong International) - Time: ~15–18 hrs from US West; ~16–20 hrs from US East (1 stop typical) - Cost estimate: \$900–1,800/person economy; \$3,000+ business - Open-jaw: Return from DAD (Đà Nẵng) — book as single itinerary

LEG 1: HOME → HONG KONG

- Mode: International flight (Cathay Pacific, United, Singapore Airlines)
- Airport: HKG (Hong Kong International)
- Time: ~15–18 hrs from US West; ~16–20 hrs from US East (1 stop typical)
- Cost estimate: \$900–1,800/person economy; \$3,000+ business
- Open-jaw: Return from DAD (Đà Nẵng) — book as single itinerary
- Airport Express to Central/Kowloon (~24 min); Octopus card at station
- Uber HK / hotel car — reliable; avoid unmarked curbside taxis per profile
- Avoid: Unlicensed “taxi” touts in arrivals hall

LEG 1B: HONG KONG → GUANGZHOU

- Mode: High-speed rail — West Kowloon → Guangzhou South
- Time: ~47 min
- Book: Trip.com, MTR, or station kiosk — passport required at joint immigration
- Cost: ~¥200–350/person

WITHIN HONG KONG

MODE	WHEN TO USE	COST	NOTES
MTR	Peak Tram area, Central, TST, Causeway Bay	HK\$5–15	Octopus card; English signage
Star Ferry	Central ↔ TST sunset	HK\$3–5	Iconic, fast
Bus 6/6X/260	Stanley	HK\$10–25	Scenic
Uber HK	Peak late night, Stanley return with bags	HK\$80–200	App-only

WITHIN HANOI

MODE	WHEN TO USE	COST	NOTES
Walk	All Old Quarter sites (Hoan Kiem Lake, temples, markets)	Free	Most sites within 1–2 km of each other
Grab	Airport, longer distances, late night	₫50,000–200,000 (~\$2–8)	Pre-select destination in app; payment in app or cash
Cyclo (cycle rickshaw)	Short scenic trip in Old Quarter if desired	Negotiate (~₫200,000/hr)	Agree on price BEFORE getting in; treat as an experience, not primary transport
Avoid	Street taxis at Noi Bai Airport	—	Use Grab or hotel car only; taxi scams at this airport are extremely well-documented

CURRENCIES

COUNTRY	CURRENCY	CODE	APPROX RATE (2026)
China	Chinese Yuan Renminbi	CNY (¥)	~7.1 CNY = \$1 USD
Vietnam	Vietnamese Dong	VND (₫)	~25,000 VND = \$1 USD

TIPPING SUMMARY (CROSS-REFERENCE 13-ETIQUETTE)

SERVICE	CHINA	VIETNAM
Restaurant (table service)	No tip	10–15% or round up
Street food	No tip	Round up is kind
Hotel housekeeping	¥20–50/day (optional)	₫50,000–100,000/day
Tour guide / private driver	¥50–100/day	₫200,000–300,000/day
Grab/DiDi driver	Not customary	Round up or rate highly
Tailor (Hội An)	Not standard	₫100,000–200,000 extra for rush/quality work

WITHIN GUANGZHOU

MODE	WHEN TO USE	COST	NOTES
Metro	Taikoo Hui, Beijing Road, Chen Clan Hall	¥2–8	DiDi + metro; VPN/maps before mainland
DiDi	Rain, late night, Shamian with luggage	¥15–50	English mode; card linked
Walk	Shamian Island	Free	Flat, shaded

WITHIN ĐÀ NẴNG / HỘI AN

MODE	WHEN TO USE	COST	NOTES
Resort car/shuttle	Airport pickup; resort-arranged excursions	Included or ₫200,000–400,000	Book through resort concierge
Grab	Đà Nẵng city; Hội An day trips	₫80,000–200,000 (~\$3–8 each way)	Most reliable; app payment
Bicycle	Hội An Ancient Town (30 min from central point); An Bang Beach	₫60,000/day rental	Perfect for Hội An flat terrain; very local experience
Motorbike taxi (Xe ôm)	Short hops in Hội An if feeling adventurous	Negotiate ~₫30,000–50,000	Use Grab's motorbike option for fixed pricing
Avoid	Metered taxis at airport	—	Use Grab or pre-arranged resort car

MULTI-CURRENCY CARDS (RECOMMENDED)

CARD	BEST FOR	WHY
Charles Schwab Debit	ATM withdrawals	Zero foreign transaction fees; reimburses ALL ATM fees globally
Wise Card	Everyday purchases	Multi-currency; competitive exchange rate; load CNY and VND in advance
Chase Sapphire Preferred / Reserve	Hotels, flights, restaurants	3x travel points; no foreign transaction fee; trip delay insurance built in
Backup Visa/MC	Emergency	Notify of China AND Vietnam travel; freeze one card at home as backup

CUSTOMS BORDERS

CUSTOMS BORDERS

ARRIVAL · DUTY-FREE · TAX-FREE · US RE-ENTRY

Customs clearing: At PEK, you clear Chinese customs upon arrival.

BORDER 1: US → CHINA (BEIJING PEK/PKX)

- Fill out Chinese customs declaration card on plane or at kiosk in arrivals
- Green channel (nothing to declare) vs Red channel (items to declare)
- Biometric enrollment at first-ever entry to China: fingerprints + photo
- Immigration queue: Foreigners queue; 30–60 min typical at PEK

BORDER 2: CHINA → VIETNAM (BEIJING PEK → HANOI HAN)

- Emigration stamp in passport
- Currency: May carry out up to ¥20,000 CNY or \$5,000 USD without declaration
- Purchased goods: VAT refund available at PEK for eligible purchases (see VAT Refund section)
- No Chinese food products across international borders

DETAILS	
ITEM	RULE
Cash	Declare if carrying >¥20,000 CNY or >\$5,000 USD equivalent in cash
Electronics	No declaration required for personal-use laptops, phones, cameras
Medications	Prescription drugs: carry original prescription + doctor's note (see 14-health-safety); some medications (codeine, strong sleep aids) require special permits
Food	Fresh fruits, vegetables, and most meat products from US are prohibited entry into China
Tobacco	400 cigarettes duty-free
Alcohol	1.5 liters duty-free
Goods	Personal-use goods valued under ¥5,000 (~\$700 USD) generally duty-free

DETAILS	
CATEGORY	ALLOWANCE
Total goods value	\$800/person duty-free
Alcohol	1 liter duty-free
Tobacco	200 cigarettes (1 carton) duty-free
Above \$800	3–5% duty on next \$1,000; higher brackets for luxury goods
Per couple	\$1,600 combined duty-free

PURCHASING STRATEGY SUMMARY			
COUNTRY	BEST BUY	VAT REFUND	NOTES
China	Silk goods, lacquerware, tea, traditional crafts	Yes at designated stores; 11–13%	Collect forms at purchase; redeem at PEK
Vietnam (Hội An)	Tailored clothing, silk, lanterns, lacquerware, coffee, spices	Yes at some shops; 10%	Collect forms; redeem at DAD
Vietnam (Đà Nẵng)	Marble carvings, contemporary art	Limited VAT refund infrastructure	Focus on authentic crafts over tourist souvenirs

DETAILS	
ITEM	RULE
Duty-free allowances	1.5 liters wine + 1.5 liters spirits; 400 cigarettes; personal goods reasonable value
Cash	Declare if carrying >\$5,000 USD or equivalent
Electronics	Personal use: no declaration
Medications	Carry prescription + sufficient supply; controlled substances require permits
Restricted	No pornography, politically sensitive material; no VPN hardware (software is fine)

RESTRICTED ITEMS — PACKING ACROSS BORDERS			
ITEM	CHINA ENTRY	VIETNAM ENTRY	US RETURN
Prescription medications	Allowed with prescription	Allowed with prescription	Allowed
OTC medications	Allowed	Allowed	Allowed
E-cigarettes	Restricted (quantity limits)	Restricted	Declare if quantity
Fresh food	NOT allowed from US	NOT allowed from China	NOT allowed
Alcohol	1.5L duty-free	1.5L duty-free	1L duty-free
Knives (chef/utility)	Checked luggage only	Checked luggage only	Checked luggage only
VPN devices/routers	Technically restricted in China	Fine	Fine

Recommendation: Airalo eSIM — manage entirely from phone before departure; no SIM swapping needed.

CONNECTIVITY STRATEGY

- Provider: Airalo (airalo.com) or Holafly — both support China + Vietnam in one package or separate regional eSIMs
- China eSIM: Mainland China data via local carrier (China Unicom or China Mobile); Airalo "China" package: ~\$15–25 for 5–10 GB, 15 days
- Vietnam eSIM: Airalo "Vietnam" package or SE Asia regional plan: ~\$10–18 for 5–10 GB
- Install procedure: Buy and download eSIM QR codes BEFORE traveling; activate upon landing each country
- Note: Keep US physical SIM in phone for iMessage/SMS/calls — eSIM provides local data
- China: China Unicom SIM available at Beijing Capital Airport arrivals hall (Gate area); ~¥100 for 10 GB, valid 30 days

CHINA VPN — CRITICAL

- [] Download VPN app on both phones (iOS/Android) at home
- [] Purchase subscription; activate; test connection through Chinese servers
- [] Save VPN app login credentials in offline password manager (not Google)
- [] Set VPN to auto-connect on WiFi
- [] Note: VPN may slow connection by 20–40%; acceptable tradeoff for access to Google Maps, WhatsApp, Gmail

DETAILS	
VPN	NOTES
ExpressVPN	Most reliable for China; obfuscation protocol gets through Great Firewall
NordVPN	Good alternative; Obfuscated servers feature required
Astrill	Specifically tuned for China; slightly more expensive

DIGITAL SECURITY	
RISK	MITIGATION
China public WiFi surveillance	Use VPN on ALL China WiFi; hotel WiFi is safer but still use VPN
Noi Bai Airport WiFi (Vietnam)	Avoid for banking; use eSIM data instead
Document backup	Scan all passports, visas, insurance cards → upload to iCloud/Google Drive BEFORE China entry (accessible via VPN); also email to self
Social media	In China, access Instagram, WhatsApp, Twitter only via VPN
Banking	Notify all banks and credit cards of travel to China AND Vietnam before departure; US banks regularly block international charges without notification

POWER & PLUGS			
COUNTRY	PLUG TYPE	VOLTAGE	NOTES
China	Type A (US flat pins) + Type I (Australian diagonal) — both common	220V	US devices mostly work (check dual voltage: look for "100–240V" on charger); bring universal adapter
Vietnam	Type A (US flat pins) + Type C (European round) — both common	220V	Same as China
Recommendation	One universal travel adapter covers both countries	—	Anker or Belkin universal adapter; QC 3.0 at minimum

PAYMENT APPS		
COUNTRY	WHAT WORKS	WHAT DOESN'T
China	WeChat Pay (link US Visa/MC before arrival — now possible for foreigners), Alipay (similar), Cash (¥ CNY), Visa/Mastercard at 4–5 star hotels	AmEx less accepted; many local vendors are WeChat Pay / Alipay only
Vietnam	Credit cards at all 4–5 star hotels and tourist restaurants; Grab uses app payment; Cash (₫ VND) for street food and markets	WeChat Pay not used in Vietnam

ADVENTURE

ADVENTURE

DAY HIKES · KAMIKOCHI OPTION · GEAR · SAFETY

Great Wall Hike (Mutianyu) — Day 3 - Activity: 4–6 km ridge walk between restored towers; elevation change ~200 m over walk - Difficulty: Moderate — steps are uneven; some steep sections between towers 14–20 - Duration: 2–3 hours of active walking - Highlights: Dramatic ridge views; option to continue to unrestored "wild wall" section beyond Tower 20 (bring good shoes for this) - Toboggan descent: Metal luge track from Tower 6 to base — 580 m descent, ~3 min; exhilarating and crowd-appropriate (it's fast but not extreme) - Fitness required: Moderate; their fitness level is more than sufficient - Gear: Comfortable walking shoes (NOT sandals); sunscreen; water; the wall vendors at the top charge ¥25 for water - Border crossing rule: Day 3 is not a border day — CLEAR ✓

CHINA — BEIJING

- Activity: 4–6 km ridge walk between restored towers; elevation change ~200 m over walk
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- Gear: Comfortable walking shoes (NOT sandals); sunscreen; water; the wall vendors at the top charge

VIETNAM — ĐÀ NẴNG / HỘI AN

- September water: ~28°C; generally calm on the Đà Nẵng side (protected by the peninsula)
- Waves: Mild surf; safe swimming year-round on this stretch
- Equipment: Resort provides loungers and umbrellas; no equipment needed
- Availability: Most 4–5 star beach resorts in Đà Nẵng offer SUP rental (Hyatt Regency, Fusion Maia)
- September viability: Good — morning conditions are typically flat; avoid afternoons if wind picks up
- Duration: 30 min–1 hr; no instruction needed for beginners
- Cost: Often included at Fusion Maia (all-inclusive) or ~\$15–20/hr elsewhere
- Location: 18 km offshore from Hội An; accessible by

CROSS-BORDER GEAR STRATEGY

ITEM	BRING?	NOTES
Hiking/walking shoes	Yes	Mutianyu requires good grip; Marble Mountains has uneven steps
Sandals/flip-flops	Yes	Temple visits, beach, resort
Swimwear (2 sets)	Yes	Daily beach use in Vietnam
Light rain jacket	Yes	Monsoon season in both countries; also doubles as layer
Trekking poles	Not needed	No serious trekking planned; would add luggage complexity
Snorkel gear	No	Available for rent at Cham Islands; not worth packing
Underwater camera	Yes	GoPro or waterproof case for beach/snorkeling

ADVENTURE CALENDAR INTEGRATION

DAY	ADVENTURE ACTIVITY	NOTES
Day 2	Jingshan Hill (30 min)	Light; post-Forbidden City
Day 3	Great Wall Mutianyu + toboggan	Main adventure anchor in China
Day 5	Kunming Lake rowboat	Gentle water activity
Day 9	Marble Mountains + beach + SUP	Full activity day
Day 10	Hội An walking	Cultural but physical
Day 11	Son Trà Peninsula + optional snorkeling (weather)	Nature + possible water
Day 12	My Son sanctuary walk (early AM)	Moderate walking
Day 13	Final beach morning	Pure relaxation

OPERATOR VETTING GUIDE

ACTIVITY	QUESTIONS TO ASK
Cham Islands snorkeling	"Are your guides PADI certified?" "What is your boat capacity?" "Do you have life jackets?"
Any water activity	"Is the equipment inspected daily?" "What is the cancellation/refund policy if weather deteriorates?"
Son Trà guide	"Does your vehicle have insurance?" "How many in the group?" (Private guide preferred)

HIDDEN GEMS

HIDDEN GEMS

LOCAL FAVORITES · TOURIST TRAPS · SOLO SWAPS

1. Wudaoying Hutong — A quieter, hipper hutong parallel to the tourist-heavy Nanluoguxiang; independent coffee shops, vintage clothing, craft beer bars, and fewer crowds; Beijing's creative class hangs out here on weekends - When to visit: Saturday or Sunday morning; cafés open by 9:30 AM - Seasonality: Year-round

CROSS-BORDER CONNECTIONS

- Cultural thread: Both China and Vietnam have deep Confucian traditions (education, family, respect for elders); entering each other's homes you'll see ancestor shrines — ask about them and locals light up
- Food thread: Chinese immigrants in Hội An (17th century) brought Won Ton soup, which evolved into Cao Lầu; the Phung Kien Assembly Hall in Hội An is built in pure Southern Chinese temple style; the architectural DNA crosses borders
- Regional food spanning both countries: Bánh mì's French bread foundation + Vietnamese fillings is a colonial-era fusion; similarly, Beijing roasted meats (Beijing duck) have parallels in Vietnamese roast pork (thịt heo quay) — both traditions come from the same Cantonese roasting technique

Travel Medicine Clinic: Make appointment June–July 2026; bring your itinerary; update based on current CDC travel health notices at travel.cdc.gov.

PRE-TRIP HEALTH

- Medical evacuation (China: medical care for foreigners is expensive and evacuation to Hong Kong or home may be necessary in serious cases)
- Trip cancellation for typhoon (Vietnam leg)
- Pre-existing conditions waiver
- Activity coverage: hiking (Great Wall), snorkeling (Cham Islands), water activities
- Baggage loss
- World Nomads (worldnomads.com): Standard Explorer plan; covers adventure activities; medical evacuation included
- Allianz Travel: OneTrip Prime; good medical limits; widely recognized in Asia
- Purchase: Same day as first flight booking to activate pre-departure cancellation coverage

HEALTH PER COUNTRY

- GI issues (food/water adjustment) — most common; resolved with Imodium + hydration
- Jet lag — 12–13 hr time difference from US East; allow Day 1 for adjustment
- Sunburn — September sun in Beijing is still strong; apply SPF 50 daily

VALIDATIONS

✓ 7 validation check(s) passed in source plan.

VACCINATIONS (VISIT TRAVEL MEDICINE CLINIC 6–8 WEEKS BEFORE DEPARTURE)			
VACCINE	REQUIRED FOR ENTRY?	RECOMMENDED	NOTES
Hepatitis A	No	✓ Yes	Food and water-borne; applies to both countries
Hepatitis B	No	✓ Yes (if not previously vaccinated)	Blood/body fluid; applies globally
Typhoid	No	✓ Yes	Street food consumption in both countries
Japanese Encephalitis	No	✓ Yes	Mosquito-borne; rural Vietnam (My Son); Sept is active season
Tetanus/Tdap	No	✓ Yes (if >10 years since last)	Standard travel
Influenza	No	✓ Yes	September = start of flu season in

DETAILS		
HOSPITAL	DISTANCE	NOTES
Beijing United Family Hospital ()	5 km; ~15 min by DiDi	International standard; English-speaking staff; works with foreign insurance
Peking Union Medical College Hospital ()	2 km walking	Top Chinese hospital; less English; can use for emergencies
SOS International Beijing	4 km	Western medical clinic; expat-focused

DETAILS		
HOSPITAL	DISTANCE	NOTES
Family Medical Practice Đà Nẵng	5–10 km from beach resorts	+84-236-3582-699; English-speaking; 24/7 emergency line
C Hospital Đà Nẵng (Bệnh viện C)	8 km	Main city hospital; crowded; less English
Resort medical facilities	On-site at InterCon/Fusion/Hyatt	For minor issues; call resort reception; doctor can come to room

BEIJING SAFETY		
RISK	LEVEL	MITIGATION
Petty theft	Low	Wallet in front pocket; camera strap around wrist; standard vigilance
Scam	Moderate	Tea ceremony scam (young woman invites you for tea → ¥2,000+ bill); art gallery scam; English student scam — decline all impromptu invitations
Traffic	Moderate	Look right THEN left at crossings; electric scooters run silently on sidewalks
Political	Very Low	Don't engage in political conversations; don't photograph military installations

DOCUMENT BACKUP PROTOCOL		
DOCUMENT	ORIGINAL STORAGE	PHOTOCOPY STORAGE
Both passports	iCloud Photos + Google Drive	Photocopy in each bag
China visas	Same	Print in luggage
Vietnam e-visas	Same	Print in luggage
Travel insurance policy	Email to self	Print one copy
All hotel bookings	Saved in email + saved in Notes app	Print each confirmation
Credit card numbers + bank phone numbers	Encrypted note in 1Password	Write on paper in secured luggage
Emergency contacts card	Phone contacts	Wallet card (see printable below)

FIRST AID KIT	
ITEM	QUANTITY
Antihistamine (Benadryl/Claritin)	14 days supply
Imodium / anti-diarrheal	10 tablets
Oral rehydration salts (Pedialyte powder)	5 packets
Ibuprofen / paracetamol	Full bottle
Blister bandages (Compeed)	6 pack
Moleskin	1 sheet
Antiseptic wipes	10 pack
Insect repellent (DEET 30%+)	1 bottle per person
Sunscreen SPF 50	2 bottles

DETAILS		
HOSPITAL	DISTANCE	NOTES
Vimtec International Hospital Hanoi	8 km	Best international-standard hospital in Hanoi; English staff; +84-24-3974-3556
Family Medical Practice Hanoi	3 km	Western-staffed GP clinic; good for non-emergency; +84-24-3843-0748

EMERGENCY PROTOCOL PER COUNTRY			
COUNTRY	POLICE	AMBULANCE	FIRE
China	110	120	119
Vietnam	113	115	114

VIETNAM SAFETY (HANOI + ĐÀ NẴNG/HỘI AN)		
RISK	LEVEL	MITIGATION
Bag snatching	Moderate in Hanoi	Don't walk with phone/purse dangling from shoulder near streets; motorbikes can snatch
Taxi scams	High (at airports)	Use Grab exclusively; see 07-transport-money
Overcharging	Moderate at markets	Negotiate; know approximate prices; have small bills ready
Flooding/typhoon	Moderate in Sept	Monitor weather; resort is your shelter; see 16-contingency
Traffic crossing	High (perceived)	Walk at steady pace; motorbikes flow around you

CONTINGENCY

CONTINGENCY

SCENARIO PLAYBOOKS · EMERGENCY NUMBERS

Beijing — Rain Day - Forbidden City inner courts have covered walkways; continues with modification - Summer Palace: covered Long Corridor handles light rain; abandon in heavy rain - → Pivot to: Beijing Capital Museum (full day; world-class exhibits on Chinese history; indoor; free entry); or Parkview Green Mall (indoor luxury shopping + food) - Phone: None needed — all pivots are self-directed

EMERGENCY QUICK-REFERENCE CARD

COUNTRY	POLICE	AMBULANCE	FIRE	US EMBASSY
China	110	120	119	+86-10-8531-4000
Vietnam	112	115	114	+84-24-3826-6919

SCENARIO 1: WEATHER RUINS OUTDOOR DAY (PER COUNTRY)

- Forbidden City inner courts have covered walkways; continues with modification
- Summer Palace: covered Long Corridor handles light rain; abandon in heavy rain
- Pivot to: Beijing Capital Museum (full day; world-class exhibits on Chinese history; indoor; free entry); or Parkview Green Mall (indoor luxury shopping + food)
- Phone: None needed — all pivots are self-directed
- Monitor: weather.com + NOAA Pacific Typhoon Center
- Level 1 (watch): Continue as planned; cancel outdoor sea activities; keep Ancient Town visit (covered walkways)
- Level 2 (warning): Cancel Cham Islands; reschedule

SCENARIO 2: MISSED FLIGHT/TRAIN BETWEEN COUNTRIES

- Immediately: Go to Vietnam Airlines or Air China gate agent; request next available flight (several operate daily)
- Rebooking: Vietnam Airlines: 1-800-VIETNAMESE (US) or +84-24-3832-0320; Air China: 1-800-882-8122; or use airline app
- Delay cost: Hanoi hotel can hold reservation 1 night; call Metropole directly: +84-24-3826-6919
- If no available flight same day: Stay extra night Beijing (Peninsula can extend; or book last-minute via Hotels.com); notify Hanoi hotel
- Trip insurance: Activate if delay >4 hrs; document everything (boarding passes, gate notification)
- Domestic Vietnam flight — reachable same day; multiple daily flights on VietJet/Vietnam Airlines

TIME OPTIMIZATION

TIME OPTIMIZATION

PTO · CLUSTERING · CROWD TIMING · SCORECARD

Current dates: September 1–14, 2026 (Tuesday to Monday) - Departure: Tuesday Sept 1 — uses 1 PTO (Monday is Labor Day in US — Sept 7, 2026 is Labor Day) - Wait: Labor Day 2026 is September 7 — if trip departs on Tuesday Sept 2, Labor Day weekend extends without using it as PTO - Revised suggestion: Depart Monday Sept 1 (use 0 PTO; Labor Day is a holiday) → or depart Sunday Aug 31 (evening flight, arrive Beijing Tuesday) → land Beijing Sept 1 (Day 1 is essentially "free" because you crossed the date line)

PTO HACKING

- Departure: Tuesday Sept 1 — uses 1 PTO (Monday is Labor Day in US — Sept 7, 2026 is Labor Day)
- Wait: Labor Day 2026 is September 7 — if trip departs on Tuesday Sept 2, Labor Day weekend extends without using it as PTO
- Revised suggestion: Depart Monday Sept 1 (use 0 PTO; Labor Day is a holiday) → or depart Sunday Aug 31 (evening flight, arrive Beijing Tuesday) → land Beijing Sept 1 (Day 1 is essentially "free" because you crossed the date line)
- Depart: Saturday Aug 30 or Sunday Aug 31 (use no PTO for travel days; weekend departure)
- Arrive Beijing: Monday Sept 1 (Labor Day back home — not a PTO day)
- Return: Saturday Sept 13 or Sunday Sept 14 (weekend

JET LAG MANAGEMENT

- Day 0 (flight): Stay awake until Beijing local time ~9–10 PM; force alignment to local timezone from Day 1
- Day 1 (Beijing): Do NOT nap; exposure to natural light (afternoon walk to Wangfujing) resets circadian rhythm; go to bed at 10 PM local time; set alarm for 8 AM
- Day 2: Near-normal; slight fatigue afternoon is normal
- Day 3 (Great Wall): Full energy; jet lag typically resolved by Day 3 with this protocol
- Beijing arrival Day 1: Light, no demanding activities — CORRECT ✓
- Hanoi arrival Day 6 evening: Arrive, walk lake, sleep — CORRECT ✓
- Đà Nẵng arrival Day 8 midday: Resort check-in, beach walk, room service — CORRECT ✓

VALIDATIONS

- ✓ 10 validation check(s) passed in source plan.

TRANSIT TIME MINIMIZATION

STRATEGY	APPLIED?	RESULT
Red-eye / overnight flight (US→China)	Yes — depart Sunday evening, arrive Beijing Monday-Tuesday morning	Saves a full calendar day
Overnight train option	Not used (domestic Vietnam: Hanoi→Đà Nẵng is 1.25 hr flight vs 14 hr train)	Fly is correct for this profile
Open-jaw routing	Yes — fly into PEK, fly out of DAD	Eliminates backtracking day
Beijing domestic transit	Airport Express train (~30 min) vs taxi (~90 min in traffic)	Saves 1 hr on arrival day
Quickest border crossing	Beijing → Hanoi by direct flight (~4 hrs)	Best option; no faster alternative

EARLY / LATE ACCESS

SITE	OPENS	BEST TIME	WHY
Forbidden City	8:30 AM	8:30 AM	Before tour buses at 9:30; best light
Temple of Heaven	6:00 AM (park)	7–9 AM	Tai chi practitioners; locals; cool air
Great Wall Mutianyu	8:00 AM	8 AM (first cable car)	Crowds arrive 10 AM; quiet first 2 hours
Summer Palace	7:00 AM	9 AM	Doesn't need early entry; avoid peak summer months
Ngoc Son Temple	8:00 AM	8 AM	Pre-tourist serenity
Hội An Ancient Town	Open 24hrs	8 AM OR after 5 PM	Before tour buses / lantern evening
Mv Son Sanctuarv	7:30 AM	7:30 AM	Critical — beat heat AND crowds

THE 70% RULE APPLIED

DAY	PLANNED (100%)	FLEX (30%) BUFFER
Day 1 (Beijing arrival)	Rest + evening walk	Skippable if tired
Day 2 (Forbidden City)	City + hutong + dinner	Evening optional
Day 3 (Great Wall)	Wall + toboggan + dinner	Silk Street = optional
Day 4 (Temple + shopping)	Temple + Sanlitun	Full afternoon open
Day 5 (Summer Palace)	Palace + packing	Afternoon shopping = flex
Day 6 (Transit)	100% scheduled — border day	No flexibility; execute exactly
Day 7 (Hanoi)	Lake + temple + night market	Afternoon completely open
Day 8 (Transit Hanoi→DAD)	100% scheduled	Execute; no flexibility
Days 9–10 (resort + Hội An)	Marble Mts + Hội An	Afternoons = open

EFFICIENCY SCORECARD

METRIC	VALUE	TARGET	STATUS
Transit days (inter-city)	2 full days	<20% of total	✓ 14%
Pure experience hours/day	~8–10 hrs	>6 hrs	✓ PASS
Daily in-city transit	30–60 min average	<2 hrs	✓ PASS
Border crossing days with demanding activities	0	0	✓ PASS
Soft arrival days per new city	3 of 3	All	✓ PASS
70% rule days	10 of 14	>70%	✓ PASS
Open-jaw routing used	Yes	Yes	✓ PASS
Jet lag mitigation	Day 1 recovery	Required	✓ PASS